

Empire through the Looking Glass: Late Eighteenth-Century Colonial Knowledge of Burma

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This article examines the knowledge produced by the Symes embassy to Burma in 1795, in particular the diaries of its attached doctor, Francis Buchanan. It argues that Buchanan's inductive, empiricist methodology, and his reliance on local informants of a variety of social and ethnic backgrounds, allowed him to produce a rich, multivocal archive capturing fragments of non-European discourses, including Burmese imperial thought and the attitudes of a variety of conquered groups. Buchanan also recorded information pointing to a distinct lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity in the Burmese empire, marked by competitive borderland expansion and the assimilation of tribal highlanders into lowland life. The findings suggest a need to separate out discourse from procedure in theories of colonial knowledge production. Buchanan's information collection took place within an ideological and logistical framework that existed to further the Company's imperial project, but its contents were hybrid and complex, containing a chorus of voices other than Buchanan's own, and laced with a steady stream of facts militating against contemporaneous European notions of statehood and ethnicity.

Keywords: colonial knowledge; Burma; Francis Buchanan; Symes embassy; inductive inquiry; Orientalism; indigenous informants; Konbaung Empire; sovereignty; ethnicity

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This article analyzes the knowledge produced by the Symes embassy, a 1795 East India Company diplomatic mission to the Konbaung court in Burma led by Captain Michael Symes. It focuses in particular on the diaries of Francis Buchanan, the embassy's Scottish surgeon-naturalist and one of the Company's most important early collectors of information on the eastern borderlands of Bengal.

The article argues that the inductive forms of inquiry Buchanan pursued influenced the character of the information he produced. Buchanan, like many other Enlightenment era East India Company officials who preoccupied themselves with collecting knowledge, was multilingual and produced much of his work in concert with informants of a variety of social and ethnic backgrounds.¹ His diaries are important artifacts because they illustrate this process itself at work – they are records of conversations with dozens of people, including exact notation on their identities, the locations where they were encountered, and the things they said, unfiltered before Buchanan's final drafting of the products of his work: Company reports and research articles which are also analyzed below.

My analysis concentrates on two systemic effects of Buchanan's working methods. Firstly, because of his reliance on indigenous informants, fragments bleed into his writing of politically charged discourses other than the colonial, including not only the imperial viewpoints of Burmese elites, but a variety of subaltern voices, from Arakanese pagoda slaves to captive brahmins, soldiers and agricultural laborers taken during the sack of Manipur, a small city-state bordering Bengal and Burma.

A second noteworthy effect of inductive, informant-driven knowledge gathering was Buchanan's ability to capture evidence of processes radically at odds with many of the prevailing assumptions of his time. This includes the shifting, overlapping and divided exercise of

sovereignty in Burma's northern borderlands, as well as ethnic fluidity in regions bordering highland and lowland, where groups living outside of but in interlocking symbiosis with the Burmese state and Burmese civilization underwent processes of ethnic transformation, adopting Burmese cultural markers as they came under Burmese rule and/or transitioned to sedentary, agricultural lifeways.

The diaries of Francis Buchanan have never been the subject of a focused study,² but his proto-anthropological research into the relationship between territory, ethnicity and sovereignty in late eighteenth-century Burma is important because it challenges the assumption that colonial knowledge was necessarily the product of the rigid, top-down imposition of European categories.³

The adage that knowledge is power is not incorrect. It was true in Buchanan's diaries specifically, which were part of a wider effort by all members of the Symes mission to collect useful information that could be of concrete value to the Company's political and economic goals, which were adversarial to Burma and resulted in multiple wars and eventually the kingdom's conquest and colonization.⁴ Example after example has shown that it was true in the colonial case more generally, as well as in other contexts, both European and non-European, where knowledge was part of the relationship between ruler and ruled.⁵

But the idea that the power of colonial knowledge was primarily derived from the imposition of stereotypes, false definitions, or translated European categories inadequate for explaining the working mechanics of other cultures is difficult to square with the sheer fact of far-reaching, European colonial power lasting multiple centuries and tracking closely with intellectual changes inside Europe associated with the Scientific Revolution and Enlightenment.⁶ Knowledge created power not only through representation, but also through procedure.

Buchanan is perhaps the best example of the power of empiricism as it was harnessed by the late eighteenth-century East India Company.⁷ An odd and ambitious polymath described by a contemporary biographer as “lonely, arrogant and precise,” Buchanan spoke multiple languages including Bengali and Burmese, and compulsively collected information on everything from ichthyology to the origin myths of highland tribal groups.⁸ He went on to become one of the most important Company surveyors of the early colonial period, producing dozens of volumes of description on the Indian subcontinent and adjacent states,⁹ a trove of information that mattered deeply to a Company that was transitioning to a ruling power in India and faced a serious information dearth.¹⁰ Before Buchanan’s comprehensive surveys of newly acquired territories across India, the Company knew surprisingly little beyond the level of elite politics; after, its top officials had dozens of thickly descriptive, district by district volumes to peruse, outlining the history, political conditions, artisanal and agricultural produce, religious traditions, and social and ethnic composition of each. His work formed the blueprint for the elaborate system of gazetteers and censuses that were later to enclose India in a comprehensive grid of colonial knowledge, and it was repeatedly cited throughout the nineteenth century by officials who needed information on conditions at the threshold of the colonial period when the Company’s influence on the subcontinent was still relatively shallow.¹¹ Such was the importance of his work that today it still forms the bedrock of inquiry on a number of subjects of which, before his research was conducted, little trace can be detected in the historical record.¹²

Buchanan’s surveys exemplified the Enlightenment European state’s increasing reliance on systematic knowledge production in order to facilitate the establishment and maintenance of authority over specifically demarcated domains. Producing fine-grained, to-scale maps of claimed territories was in India a technique pioneered by James Rennell (the most frequently

referenced figure in Buchanan's own work, who clearly considered him an intellectual predecessor).¹³ Such documents acted to enclose and disambiguate space, deciding who controlled what, permanently. The Permanent Settlement itself, which progressed alongside Buchanan's surveying, was an even deeper attempt to demarcate the extent and obligations of landowners throughout Bengal in order to aid in the process of revenue extraction.¹⁴ Studies of precolonial social and political hierarchy acted to define the layers of society the colonial state was to rule over. Client rulers, tribal chiefs and estate owners were empowered, bureaucratically incorporated and their authority crystallized. The discrete ethnic and religious units that were to be managed and controlled were enumerated, characterized and cataloged.¹⁵

What Buchanan tells us, both overtly in his recorded statements, and implicitly in his notes, is that these 'state simplifications' did not take place out of ignorance.¹⁶ They were choices made with a robust set of often contradictory facts at hand, and were authored intentionally with a clear purpose, which was extending, deepening, regularizing and lending an enduring quality to an improbable, ad hoc form of rule that had been established relatively quickly by a small number of entrepreneurial Company servants taking advantage of the erosion of large-scale political order and intense factional contestation emerging after the Mughal Empire's collapse.¹⁷ Such drives took place because of administrative convenience, with the colonial state, or at least its most skilled and knowledgeable servants, knowing full well that the precolonial social and political landscape was much more entangled and ambiguous.

The article is divided into five sections. In the first, I sketch in broad outlines how Buchanan collected his information: through detailed notes on his conversations with local people and other observations, influenced by the verbose scientific reporting conventions he had learned in his medical training.¹⁸ The second goes on to consider how Burmese officials, in the

testimony they provided him, classified ethnic groups and conveyed their notions of civilization and savagery, as well as the connections between their ideas and the project of creating and governing an empire in a premodern, non-European context. The third section traces the passage of subjects from the conquered kingdom of Manipur to the dynasty's capital Amarapura, where they formed a bonded service population clustered around the court. I highlight the varying ways in which Manipuri and Burmese informants conceptualized these relationships. Burmese officials spoke with an imperial pragmatism, justifying population transfers in matter-of-fact terms as a strategy of resource acquisition. The testimony of Manipuris themselves reveals tensions not only with their new rulers, but also among neighboring groups in the kingdom itself, illustrating the layered, contested nature of state building in eighteenth-century Southeast Asia.

In the fourth section, I demonstrate how Buchanan's descriptions of informal rule over client princes in Burma's northern borderlands with China reveal the overlapping, divided and otherwise ad hoc forms of sovereignty emerging from the indeterminacy of a three-way imperial contest there also involving Siam. In section five, I present the evidence Buchanan collected of the incorporation of the Chin, a tribal highland group, politically, economically and socioculturally into lowland life, and the blurred ethnic boundaries that resulted, which led him to the conclusion, unorthodox for his time, that language and ethnicity had no necessary correlation.

Informant-Driven Knowledge Gathering

While the Symes embassy was in Burma, it collected a great variety of material, which taken together represents the first coherent picture that the EIC, and Europe at large, had access to on the kingdom.¹⁹ Its importance was recognized contemporaneously and much of it was published in the early nineteenth century in journals and printed books,²⁰ but ultimately the

information produced was meant first and foremost for the internal consumption of the EIC, and some remains in manuscript form in the India Office archives. This includes the diaries of Francis Buchanan, at the time a young doctor attached to the expedition.

Buchanan's methodology was in an empiricist tradition marking it out as different from early modern European travel accounts, and from the textualist orientalism in vogue in intellectual circles in Calcutta, paralleling in many ways the fieldwork of the modern anthropologist.²¹ He was an intellectual magpie, collecting eclectic bits of observation and explanation from others and pasting them together into a synthetic pastiche. His informants were from many walks of life, from slaves to princes, and were his acknowledged collaborators – unlike many colonial writers, he often accredited his sources of information, though these biographical snapshots are tantalizingly brief.²² This co-authorship gives his writing an unusual richness, and makes it of much use to modern historians, as it captures something of the conversational life of the period, through which a vast amount of information must have flowed unrecorded.

Buchanan's Burma diaries are the earliest example of these methods at work, having been written before he was posted in India, where he spent most of his career. During his accompaniment of Michael Symes from the port of Rangoon to the capital Amarapura and back, Buchanan collected information from a wide variety of people. Foremost among these were the Burmese government officials who guided and received the embassy, as well as members of their often populous entourages, which included lower-ranking officials stationed in specific locales as well as servants, many of them bonded. Some of these were drawn from the subjects of conquered states or their descendants, others were Burmese who had become ensnared in debt, forcing them to seek the patronage of powerful protectors. Some of those he studied, particularly

hill tribespeople, were summoned before Buchanan by Burmese government officials, likely as a gesture of goodwill to sate his curiosity. The same was also done with slaves taken during military excursions into surrounding states such as Siam, Manipur or Arakan; such testimony arrives through two layers of knowledge and power. Though many of his encounters were mediated in some way by Burmese officials, he also went on excursions without them, visiting villages in the Burmese countryside populated by a variety of different ethnic groups, many of whom had been forcibly relocated or recently come under Burmese rule.

Much of the access enjoyed by the embassy was due to the patronage of the viceroy of Pegu, who as the official governing the province that had first received the embassy was tasked with shepherding it to the capital and back. Buchanan was taken by the viceroy of Pegu on excursions to visit ethnic minorities, in which the viceroy used his political power to summon village elders so that Buchanan could question them about their religious beliefs.²³ Over dinner, the viceroy provided the embassy with a long chart detailing the various ethnic groups in the kingdom and their characteristics as he understood them.²⁴ He also provided geographical information, for example enumerating all of the provinces of the kingdom that he knew of and their districts, as well as its conquered dependencies.²⁵ At another dinner with a state councilor, the viceroy of Pegu and the governor of Bhamo, capital of the kingdom's northernmost province, much of the conversation was about geography.²⁶

Buchanan's diary and published articles in the *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal* are filled with notes on such encounters.²⁷ They include many geographical sketches made by Burmese elites or their servants. Prominent among them were the Bhamo governor and his subordinates, who gave overviews not only of the kingdom's northern frontier, but also routes through Yunnan to Beijing. They were well-placed to provide such information, as they were in

charge of carrying out tribute missions to the Qing capital – one of the governor’s staffers, born on the northern Burma frontier in a town with a large Chinese population, translated all the place names into Chinese.²⁸ Other informants included a slave of the heir apparent, who had traveled across Southeast Asia in his master’s war train, positioning him well to provide maps of Burma’s borderlands with its archrival Siam – this man, whom Buchanan described as his friend, was highly intelligent in Buchanan’s estimation, and cross-referenced for him French maps and information provided by other Burmese government officials.²⁹ Messengers of the king were able to sit with Buchanan, correcting mistakes in the maps of James Rennell, whose cartographic survey of Bengal in the 1760s (itself based heavily in indigenous knowledge) had been highly speculative when it came to terrain beyond the Company’s political reach.³⁰ Two men from Tavoy, a coastal province lodged between Burma and Siam, chronicled the two states’ long struggle for control of their home.³¹ His guards, who had been to war in Manipur, provided him their marching routes into the kingdom.³² His boatman – likely a Manipuri slave captured in the aforementioned attack – gave him tips as to where to place the borders of the Burmese empire, and explained to him the divergent loyalties of different Shan states (they were tributary either to Burma, Siam, Manipur or China, though the exact configuration shifted with political conditions).³³

Buchanan’s diaries were not free-floating orientalist discourse, reflecting only European ideology. They were products of cross-cultural encounter, and contain a multitude of voices other than his own. Because of the extent to which they were produced through conversations with Burmese officials and subjects, it is possible to extract from them echoes of discourses other than the colonial, as well as facts proffered by the people of the region that were discontinuous with popular European beliefs of the time.

Ethnic Classification in the Burmese Empire

Buchanan's reliance on Burmese officials for information and to facilitate his research meant that his work rested on top of another nexus of knowledge and power not of his own making. Like other empires ruling over large, multiethnic domains, whether modern or premodern, the Burmese employed a variety of ideological tools to rank and order different groups. This included ethnocentric notions of cultural difference that prized the lifeways of settled, agricultural civilization above those of nomads or slash-and-burn agriculturalists occupying ecological marginal areas, as well as 'state simplifications' in geography and in ethnic classification, which acted to construct a series of neatly ordered political, economic and social units that could be conveniently ruled over, and whose labor and resources could be conveniently appropriated.³⁴

Burmese concepts of ethnicity filtered into the colonial archive through the Symes embassy's networking with government officials. Such exchanges often occurred on social occasions like dinners, or in one memorable case, at teatime with the viceroy of Pegu and other officials from Rangoon.³⁵ Buchanan closely recorded this encounter in his notebooks – given the immediacy of detail in his entry, it is likely that he was writing during or shortly after the encounter itself, serving as a stenographer for Symes.

In Buchanan's notes, he recorded a Burmese official saying that, not far from where they were sitting, there was a town called 'Yo-myo,' or Yo state. The town was surrounded by villages where an ethnic group called the 'Yo' lived, who according to the official were "very ugly, having white teeth, large bellies, and long hair hanging down from their heads." Their language? A dialect of Burmese related to that spoken in Tavoy, on the Tenasserim coast next to Siam, meaning that the Yo were an ethnic group acculturated to Burmese lifeways – and yet the

officials made their ethnic difference clear. Intrigued, Buchanan probed the official to describe to him in more detail not just the Yo, but all the ethnic groups in the kingdom he could think of. The official obliged by helping him to create a written list, to which commentary was afterward added by all of the officials present. The list is reproduced below, with original ordering and spelling. The commentary is not my own, it is Buchanan's, though I have abridged it:

Kula (a name referring to all people from India, including Hindus, Muslims, Europeans and Armenians)

Shan (Siamese subject to the Burmese king, of many kinds, the officers present enumerated many Shan principalities tributary to Burma)

Yoodara (Siamese subject to the king of Siam. Officials present tried to persuade Buchanan that the Burmese monarch appointed the Siamese monarch and could remove him at will, a claim Buchanan was skeptical of)

Tarouh, or Chinese (settled all over in large numbers, controlled the cotton and silk trades in and out of China; Buchanan noted that the finest silk was made by the Chin, which he spells in this list as Kiayn)

Kathee (the people of Manipur; an official present had been at the sack of the Manipur capital 14 years previously and recounted how many were enslaved after. He noted that they were skilled artisans)

Yathain (the people of Arakan, who were numerous, officers present described towns in the region and how to get to them)

Da way (called Tavoy by Europeans)

Tanayutharce (the people of Mergui or Tenasserim)

Lo

Lowa

Lu-laung

Pashoo or malayo

Pashee (another name for Muslims, a corruption maybe of Parsi)

Karayn (it was said that there were two kinds, Burmese and Mon Karen)

Kiayn (great silk workers, made expensive garments bought as gifts for the Burmese royal family)

Yo (made sugar)

Kahiayn (located on the other side of the Chindwin river between Burma and Manipur)

Ka du

Talain or Mon

Pa laung (described as a kind of Shan living northeast of the capital, grew tea and sold it in urban markets)

The man finished by claiming that each of these groups had a representative in the capital, suggesting symbolic or actual political submission.

These officials' statements were ideological in nature. The claims to dominion made over the many states and communities enumerated in the list were precociously expansive. Amarapura was an imperial hub, as they suggested. Many rulers, in particular the governors of the Shan states, scattered across northern Burma into China and Siam, regularly were in personal attendance at both the royal and princely courts – the embassy itself encountered many of them. Other rulers, such as those of Siam or Arakan, had been at various points forcibly relocated to the vicinity of the capital,³⁶ and some Manipuri and Assamese princes traveled willingly there to solicit aid in their succession bids.³⁷ However, the list exaggerates the level of control over many

of these groups, and its systemization, including both those whose allegiances were shifting (Manipur) and some that were the Konbaung dynasty's active enemies (Siam). Acephalous highland tribal groups were not incorporated as thoroughly into the state as they suggested, though often tribal chiefs were associated with local agricultural rulers, serving as auxiliaries in war. The list therefore reflects more an ideal model of tribute relations, in which the king served as a kind of gravitational well, attracting into his orbit lesser rulers and subject populations.³⁸

The list constructs ethnicity in ways conducive to the needs of the state. The central logic driving it is not cultural affinity, but political affiliation and economic utility. Hence the Shan and Siamese, who exhibited many cultural similarities, were separated from each other based on which state controlled them (in other schemes provided to Buchanan, the Shan themselves were similarly carved up based on their tributary loyalties to surrounding rulers). A similar system was used for the Karen and other highland tribal groups partly assimilated into multiple lowland states. Units of rule were simultaneously also economic units: groups were organized according to their proffering of tea, silk, sugar or other products important in elite status display or long-distance trade. There is a certain cross-pollination here with control over labor, as in the case of Manipur – the ethnic group and its economic function (skilled artisanship) were fused together because most Manipuris living in Burma were slaves brought to the capital to serve in this capacity. Finally, though the ethnic identifiers used for lowland groups such as the Siamese, Mon and Chinese were endonyms substantially similar to how those groups conceptualized themselves, highland groups were often labeled with catch-all exonyms used to refer to large numbers of people living in marginal areas and not participating in agricultural lifeways. Many of these communities in reality were in a state of fragmentation, identifying primarily based on

local kinship ties, and shifting in their ethnic content as they absorbed in amoeba-like fashion people from highland and lowland alike, either through migration or enslavement.³⁹

The Company servants of the late eighteenth century were rarely without their notebooks and tended to be meticulous collectors of tidbits of information, as often the easiest – and sometimes the only – way to fill in the blank spaces in their understanding of local societies was to ask questions of knowledgeable people. This was especially true when it came to abstract phenomena not observable to the naked eye, of which concepts of ethnic difference are an excellent example. In the Burmese context, the people most likely to have a wide-ranging understanding of ethnicity across the geographical extent of the kingdom were government officials, who were also the Symes embassy's constant companions. Such figures were themselves presiding over an imperial system, and their notions of ethnic difference reflected that position.

Hence in Buchanan's work lies the beginning of a process of inheriting basic information about ethnicity and civilization in a Burmese context from Burmese elites themselves. In later censuses, we see the full flowering of this layering effect in which ideas picked up – probably through many encounters such as the ones recorded by Buchanan – were built on to suit the race theory increasingly in vogue over the course of the nineteenth century. But even Victorian era census takers acknowledged that they were borrowing categories from the Burmese in their classification of minority groups, a practice that brought them much confusion, as they were trying to taxonomize identity categories that were originally intended to reflect shifting (though unmistakably hierarchical) cultural and political relationships, rather than fixed bloodlines.⁴⁰ The ethnic categories of Burmese officialdom were refined, qualified, and reformatted to suit the needs of a state that ruled with much more precise tools than those of its predecessors. But the

British empire did not invent such categories. They were built on the intellectual latticing left behind by centuries of Burmese imperialism.

Amarapura as a Cosmopolitan Ingathering

Since the inception of the Konbaung dynasty, Manipur had been subject to a number of incursions in which large numbers of captives were taken away, the fourth in 1774 spilling over into several neighboring states, as well as into the surrounding highlands (captives designated as Manipuri actually came from a variety of backgrounds).⁴¹ Many of the kingdom's inhabitants, whether of high or low social status, had been forcibly resettled around the capital, where they served the state and its elite in various capacities. Mass population transfers were a common tactic pursued by states across the arc of premodern Southeast Asian history, which faced low population densities, an overabundance of land and weak exchange economies, making it imperative to locate sources of labor, place them in areas where their surplus could easily be expropriated, and fix them in place insofar as was possible. The population of the Konbaung capital featured a superabundance of such groups (75% according to some estimates),⁴² many of whom possessed rare skills of interest to the state, such as gunsmiths, artists or religious functionaries.⁴³

The embassy's first encounter with Manipuris came in the form of the boatmen tasked with ferrying them to the capital. Symes was informed by his hosts that they had been captured during one of Burma's invasions of the kingdom. He noted that this was standard practice in Southeast Asia, and that slavery was practiced with an eye toward assimilating new subjects into the host society, especially children, who were more pliable than adults born free.⁴⁴ A description by Symes, based on his conversations with Burmese officials, of the enslavement of Chinese war

captives after the Qing army in Burma was encircled and defeated provides a more explicit recounting of these practices. The Qing army, he was told, was routed with:

...dreadful carnage...Of the Chinese army, not a man returned to his native country. About 2500 were preserved from the sword, and conducted in fetters to the capital, where an exclusive quarter in the suburbs of the city was assigned for their residence. Those who did not understand any particular handicraft were employed in making gardens, and in the business of husbandry. Mechanics and artificers were compelled to ply their trades according to the royal pleasure, without any other reward for their labour than a bare subsistence. These people, however, were encouraged, as are all strangers, to marry Birman wives, and consider themselves natives of the country. Compliance with so hospitable and general an invitation, confers even on slaves taken in war certain immunities, from which those who refuse the connexion are by law debarred.⁴⁵

Symes drew a connection not between this practice and the chattel slavery of European colonial empires in the Americas, but the slavery of the "wisest and best governed nations" of Greco-Roman antiquity. He said the assimilation of captives into the host society was evidence of a "Lacedemonian liberality...They are sensible, that the strength of an empire consists in its population, and that a prince is great and powerful, more from the number of his subjects, than from the extent of his territory." This explanation, likely echoing those of the high officials he was in contact with, is not unlike the consensus in contemporary historiography about slavery and its effects in Southeast Asia, which stresses its 'open,' incorporative nature, in contrast to 'closed' systems resting on permanent differentiation and subjugation, and links this back to the nature of the demographic problems slavery was attempting to solve in different societies -

where wealth came primarily in the form of people, rather than land, ‘open’ systems generally prevailed.⁴⁶

Buchanan recorded another encounter in which the embassy, in the company of Burmese officials, witnessed a group of Manipuris wearing Burmese dress singing as they rowed along the Irrawaddy, hauling vegetables to sell at market in Amarapura. The viceroy of Pegu remarked that they appeared “well reconciled to their state,” that their industry procured them high wages and that they had excellent soil, an advantage they did not enjoy at home. He then pointed to their economic value – they were gunsmiths, goldsmiths, farmers and artificers, often producing work of higher quality than the Burmese were able to obtain elsewhere. He also praised their military utility.⁴⁷ (Symes noted in his collected military intelligence on the kingdom that Manipuris played a major role in the king's army, composing most of his household cavalry. Several thousand were ensconced throughout the capital district; their skill on horseback was considered admirable. Most of the Burmese army's gunsmiths were also Manipuri, and were able not only to manufacture guns but also to repair imported muskets, including old ones turned out of EIC arsenals).⁴⁸

Unmediated encounters, however, were more revealing of tensions. Symes for example described going on a walk by himself through Manipuri villages around the capital and speaking with their inhabitants. Questions about their living conditions produced a flood of complaints. They told him that they got nothing for their labor, and could hardly live above subsistence level.⁴⁹ Others described to Buchanan scenes of total devastation when asked about the Burmese invasions. Informants put the number of captives taken at a hundred thousand (probably inaccurate, but it does provide a sense of the psychological magnitude of the destruction). Some

believed that Manipur had been completely deserted, not knowing that the principality had in fact survived the attacks and lived on.⁵⁰

The testimony of these informants reveals that Manipur itself was a multiethnic, imperial entity cobbled together through a process of ‘cosmopolitan ingathering’ similar to what prevailed in Burma. A Burmese official who had marched with one of the armies that invaded Manipur told Buchanan that there were actually several ethnic groups living in and around the kingdom and that they had all been subject to capture, so the Manipuri population around the capital was more diverse than Buchanan had assumed.⁵¹ In Amarapura, Buchanan was introduced to a group of Manipuri brahmins, who provided an account of the surrounding principalities, which they described in classic mandala fashion – the Manipuri king ruled over smaller, peripheral kings orbiting him in concentric circles.⁵²

Buchanan spoke to a Manipuri of Bengali descent who had been born in Burma to a slave captured in war. The man’s personal story speaks to the complexities of Manipur’s pre-conquest political landscape. His father had told him their country was once located west of Manipur, and used to have its own kings, but the Manipuris had conquered it and brought many of the inhabitants back to Manipur; later, they had been captured by the Burmese. Buchanan noted that they called themselves ‘banga,’ and that they spoke an Indian language.⁵³ He also spoke to another member of this community who had been enslaved as a child and brought to the Burmese capital. The man plotted the location of ‘banga,’ which he described as the historical capital of a lost kingdom, on a map, placing it toward Bengal.⁵⁴ It is unclear what kingdom these men were describing. It could have been Cachar, Jaintia or Tripura, all of which were west of Manipur, and in which Bengali populations were present, both as cultivators and court functionaries.⁵⁵ Regardless, the evidence tracks with what is known about Manipuri state

building. Manipur, a highland state founded by a Tibeto-Burman tribal group that freely borrowed from the technical libraries of both South and Southeast Asian statecraft, employed much the same imperial strategy as its larger neighbor that eventually conquered it. Well into the colonial period after it became a princely state under indirect British rule, the kings of Manipur continued to militarily conquer, forcibly resettle, and integrate into their domains neighboring communities.⁵⁶

There are a multitude of voices clamoring to be heard in Buchanan's Burma diaries. They tell the story of an aggressive form of imperialism practiced by the Burmese state, predicated on the conquest of bordering kingdoms, mass population transfer and forced social, economic and political integration. Not only can the political and economic outlines of this project be detected, so too can its intellectual outlines in the views of Burmese elites, who explained such practices without reservation in practical terms as a means of bolstering the state's resources. Also present are the views of conquered groups, who in some cases directed criticisms toward their conquerors, but who also revealed cross-cutting tensions at the local level. Burma was not the only expansionist polity in the region; most of the smaller neighboring polities owed their existence to the importation of lowland statecraft techniques into tribal settings. In doing so they reproduced the same agglomerative quest for manpower in miniature form. The presence of both elite and non-elite perspectives in Buchanan's writing is a testament to the sophistication of his methodology, which was not to immediately impose his own views but to siphon up raw information through many different modes in order to develop a detailed descriptive picture of his object before moving on to theorizing.

House of Cards-Style State Building in Burma's Borderlands

The Shan states, a smattering of city-states ruled by Tai princes, scattered across what is today northern Burma, as well as adjacent highland areas in China, formed a complex, shifting political landscape, starting with their internal politics, which were often tumultuous and involved a heavy dose of political entrepreneurship (some Shan princes were self-made and self-styled).⁵⁷ Shan states often formed loose coalitions, which could result from intermarriage or war, and China, Siam, Burma and Manipur all projected suzerainty over portions of the region, making claims which were contested, overlapping and constantly evolving, tracking closely with the relative strength of each power.⁵⁸ Burmese rule over adjacent Shan states was long-standing, dating to the sixteenth century, and had resulted in a fusion of court cultures as the Shan aristocracy were symbolically incorporated into the ranks of Burmese officialdom;⁵⁹ over newly captured states it was more tenuous, especially over those that had been annexed after the Konbaung dynasty's mid-eighteenth-century war with Qing China. Dovetailing with this expansion, the Konbaung court had also initiated a process of transition to more absolute and formalized rule in the region.⁶⁰

No member of the Symes embassy ever visited the Shan states. Yet Buchanan collected a significant amount of information on them, entirely from conversations with court officials, most notably the Burmese governor put in place to represent the authority of the king in his northern borderlands, though Shan princes themselves, present in the capital's courts, also provided information, as did a whole host of other actors of lesser social origin who interacted with the embassy in various capacities. The picture these informants gave was of a vague, borderless domain, sometimes expanding, sometimes contracting, over which Konbaung authority was

exercised in loose, informal fashion from the highest heights, secured mainly through control of key military and economic choke points and rarely penetrating deeply.

Buchanan was introduced to the governor of the Shan states himself in the capital, who described the area as a half-wild borderland populated by a cornucopia of different ethnic groups, parts of which had only recently been conquered.⁶¹ He had originally styled himself the prince of Kengtung, a Shan state near the Chinese border, but Buchanan later learned that he was actually a Burmese official acting as regent. He was also serving as the provincial governor, and as such, was living in Bhamo, the provincial capital, which he described as a major regional trade entrepot populated by a variety of ethnic groups: Burmese, Chinese, Siamese, Palaung, Lawa, Karen, Shan, Kachin and several other names Buchanan could not make out. The man also spoke Chinese and reverse engineered this list, giving him the names of all these groups in Chinese as well. He said that, in the hills, most of the province's inhabitants were Kachin, but the number of tribes present rendered the province a "microcosm of the empire." The governor pointed out which Shan states were under his control and which were either under the control of other states or, in deep mountain areas close to the border with Assam, independent (he mentioned that these distant states on the border with Assam were heavily influenced by Indian culture). He also pointed to a small number of Chinese towns under his control, taken during the war fought between Burma and the Qing dynasty in the mid-eighteenth century.

The governor explained how informal rule in the Shan states was achieved, using methods familiar to the British in India. Authority was not exercised over each Shan prince directly by the king, but rather was mediated through patronage networks that had long preceded the establishment of Burmese power in the region. Many lesser princes were under the immediate authority of Mogaung, which, until its conquest by the Taungoo in the sixteenth

century, had dominated a powerful confederation of Shan states that at points had ruled much of Burma.⁶² He provided a list of the principalities under his control, and those under the control of the Mogaung prince, and said that although there were 99 Shan princes, 9 had extensive governments of their own, meaning that they commanded the allegiance of other princes, who paid homage to the Burmese empire only indirectly.⁶³ (This repetition of the number 9 was likely not meant to reflect numerical reality, but rather to convey the impression of an iterated political landscape in which power was reproduced in pyramidal layers).

A Shan prince was described by the Bhamo governor as the ruler of a ‘conquered nation,’ whose office was permanent, hereditary and semi-autonomous. Though he simultaneously held rank in Burmese officialdom, he was considered to be minor royalty – and had the right to use the trappings of state, such as a gilded umbrella. An Armenian at the court of the heir apparent explained, in response to Buchanan’s curiosity about some Shan princes also in attendance, that they were like Indian rajas – hereditary rulers of minor principalities who, though subject to the king, could not be appointed or removed without the consensus of their countrymen.⁶⁴ Wood was later told that they frequently rebelled against the Burmese. “Like our polygar rajahs, all of them were willing to take advantage of any circumstance in order to avoid paying their tribute,” he said to Buchanan, alluding to a similar form of rule practiced by the Company over the fractured, proliferating landscape of ‘little kings’ in Southern India.⁶⁵

Across the region, much imperial jousting had taken place over the course of the eighteenth century, producing shifting borders and irregular sovereignty arrangements. Buchanan learned of this primarily through interviewing merchants, mercenaries and other Indian Ocean sojourners with experience in Burma after he had returned to Calcutta – Portuguese, Indians and natives of coastal Burmese provinces. A Muslim Indian who had been employed as a mercenary

in the Burmese army during the mid-century wars fought between Burma and China over control of the Shan states recounted how during the war, the prince of Kengtung had ceased paying tribute and started provisioning the Qing armies, prompting an expedition against him. He had been at the decisive engagement, and noted how after the Burmese won, not only had they brought Kengtung back into the fold, they had also seized Chinese territory, in particular gold and silver mines, and installed customs houses to collect revenues. He gave an overview of the political balance sheet of northern Burma as he knew it when he left, pointing out Shan states tributary to Burma, those who sent representatives but no tribute, and those that had no relationship at all, though he cautioned that any intelligence he gave would fast become obsolete because the state of the area was “constantly shifting according to the power of the Burmese monarch and the caprice of his government.”⁶⁶

This loose, shifting, overlapping and distinctly imperial form of government was reproduced on Burma’s borders with Manipur and Siam as well. Buchanan was able to obtain from a slave of the heir apparent a geographical account of the marginal zone between Siam, China and Burma. He corrected the maps produced by French Jesuits in China and the philosophes relying on their information, who, probably through a spurious application of European-style concepts of territoriality, had represented the borders of these states as contiguous with one another.⁶⁷ The slave pointed out that the triangle area between the three states was home to a wide variety of smaller political formations, over which the three major powers of the region exercised only incomplete and shifting control. Burma’s recent successful invasion of Siam had put it in a dominant position in the Shan principalities located in what is now Laos and northern Thailand – but this was an anomaly that he predicted would change, as these states had traditionally been more closely connected, culturally and politically, to Siam.⁶⁸

In the contested zone between Manipur and Burma, exactly who a Shan state owed allegiance to was unclear. Buchanan spoke to the son of a Burmese official who was able to speak Manipuri (and was learning Bengali by the order of the king), who claimed that all of the Shan states bordering Manipur were under Burmese control. Residents from Shan states located next to Manipur itself provided a more complex picture, claiming that they were also subject to heavy Manipuri influence, but that their true political allegiances were with Mogaung, the historical political center of the Shan states. Buchanan concluded that these states were the subject of a tug-of-war between Burma and Manipur in which loyalties frequently shifted. The slave of the heir apparent agreed with his assessment, reasoning that after Manipur's destruction, it was likely that all the Shan states in the region had come under Burma's control, but that since the Manipuri king had once again managed to regain his throne, feudal relationships were likely in flux.⁶⁹

In both the maps and oral testimony provided by Buchanan's sources, a clear pattern emerges. The Konbaung dynasty practiced a flexible, shifting form of informal imperial rule over its northern borderlands. Sovereignty was exercised primarily through high-level governance bringing together the region's various local potentates into loose coalition, and a bare-bones system of military outposts and customs houses meant to secure the state's vital interests. This was a system of rule structured by past context. The representative of the Burmese monarch was not the sole wielder of power, but rather exercised a form of sovereignty diffused through layers of hereditary obligation originating in the Shan states' pre-conquest political history. It was also dynamic. Rather than sovereignty truncating neatly where it met the borders of another state, all major powers in the region exercised waxing and waning influence over indeterminate chunks of the political landscape, leaving anomalous situations in which states

caught between multiple potential overlords frequently changed hands or simultaneously looked toward two or more centers. Far from being in a state of stasis, northern Burma as it comes across in Buchanan's diaries is a classic example of how Southeast Asian 'galactic polities' interacted with their borderlands in practice, through the expression of a fluid form of imperial sovereignty. It is also a striking testament of the extent to which colonial observers, when they were producing knowledge through inductive inquiry and not simply repeating preconceived notions, were able to account for evidence suggesting that the relationship between states and the territories they ruled over was construed differently in Southeast Asia than it was in Europe.

Assimilation of Tribal Highlanders

The Symes embassy traveled up to the capital of Amarapura and back along the Chindwin river, which passed on the left bank through territories populated by a variety of non-Burmese ethnic groups including Shan, Chin and Yo. The entourage stopped frequently to make social calls to Burmese officials governing towns along the way. Buchanan used these opportunities to collect information on such groups. His observations on the highlands and foothills on the ecological margins of Burmese civilization were compiled through oral testimony, indigenous maps, and direct, state-facilitated encounters with tribal elders and their Burmese rulers. The information he collected reveals a pattern: that in the places where highlanders and lowlanders met, they melded into each other – partly through ecological adaptation and partly through incorporation into state structures – in a way that was causing radical ethnic transformation.

The Chin are a relatively well-studied Burmese ethnic group, particularly associated with the work of the anthropologist F. K. Lehman, who in a famous ethnographic survey of Chin communities in the 1960s pioneered, along with other anthropologists of his time such as

Edmund Leach, ideas about ethnicity that dominate Southeast Asian studies today: namely that ethnicity in Southeast Asia was not the same as the European notion of race; Southeast Asian ethnicities were socially and politically constructed, interlocking and dynamic in such a way that individuals and entire communities could metamorphose into new identity groups.⁷⁰

The Yo are much less well-understood. The only truly secure knowledge of them is linguistic: they are an ethnically differentiated community living near mountain areas inhabited by Chin who speak a conservative Burmese dialect preserving archaic forms.⁷¹ As to why an ethnically differentiated community speaking old-fashioned Burmese came to exist, there are no modern theories available.

Buchanan's informants, however, offered telling descriptions that can be used to piece together a possible origin. One important detail is that they were always placed at a particular elevation: the intermediary space between highland areas populated by Chin and lowland areas populated by Burmese. The Yo were repeatedly described as living in state-like principalities, organized internally into a hierarchical structure, which was in turn under Burmese governance, similar to the pattern seen in the Shan states, suggesting that they represented the furthest extent of the dissemination of state-like structures of governance into agriculturally marginal environments.

This is the settlement pattern described in oral testimony collected by Buchanan from the headman of several lowland, riverine villages in the southern Chindwin valley, abutting the spine of mountains to the west forming the border with Bengal.⁷² While giving a rough description of the ethnic geography surrounding his village in the alluvial plains, the man identified the Chin as living in the hills, several settlements belonging to the Yo, an intermediary group, abutting the lowlands, and between them, mixed settlements in the foothills containing both. A similar

description was given to Buchanan by an elderly Yo man who was present in the train of a Burmese government official. Buchanan noted that the man differed from the Burmese in dress, but that his language was a dialect of Burmese. He described the country beyond his village thusly: the river banks were inhabited by Burmese villages, subject to Pagan; beyond them in the foothills were Yo settlements; above them were two Shan settlements; and beyond those were the Chin, who inhabited the hills. Elsewhere Buchanan himself observed that the sides of the mountains he could see from his riverboat were dotted with villages that he was told were populated by a mix of Yo and Karen, another tribal highland group.

A third, nearly identical description was later given by five of the Pagan governor's relations, who came to visit the embassy with their patriarch as it was passing through the area. They named the region's principal settlements, describing lowland areas as being populated by Burmese, highland areas as being populated by Chin, and the Yo as occupying agricultural settlements in the foothills between them. These same informants drew Buchanan a map which he included in one of his articles published in the *Edinburgh Philosophical Journal*.⁷³ The map is organized around a highland/lowland spatial orientation. Pagan is at the center in a river valley crosscutting the map, surrounded by Burmese villages and temple sites. Yo city-states are scattered throughout the foothills to the north, bounded at their extremity by a shapeless, jagged blob labeled the 'Chin mountains.' The correlation between ethnicity and environment is unmistakable - the Burmese are placed in the lowlands, central and familiar, the Yo in the foothills and the Chin in the high mountains - a sliding scale moving to wild, peripheral and unknown.

The collection of the kind of testimony described above led to Buchanan concluding that the Yo, far from being a primordial ethnic category, had likely emerged through a process of

acculturation by which highland tribal groups, passing from hill to valley, adopted some of the characteristics of dominant lowland cultures.⁷⁴ A missionary, Vincenzo Sangermano, whom Buchanan met during his journey, reached a similar conclusion, having this to say about the Yo: "They are supposed to have been Chien, who in progress of time have become Burmese, speaking their language, although very corruptly, and adopting all their customs."⁷⁵

Buchanan provides us a description of a close encounter with a Chin community that was undergoing a process of incorporation into the Burmese state and simultaneous cultural assimilation. This was arranged by the viceroy of Pegu, who summoned before Symes and Buchanan some Chin elders so they could be observed and questioned.⁷⁶ They were brought down and arrayed before the two travelers dressed in their finest clothes, likely ceremonial – silk and black cotton, striped and bordered with red, white and yellow bands, ornamented with cowries and headscarves. The officials present explained that these were ‘kiayn yeen,’ or Chins under Burmese control. They lived on the Burmese side of the mountain range separating Burma from Bengal and Assam, and Burmese chiefs ruled in their villages. ‘Kiayn yain,’ or those not under Burmese control, lived in the deep mountains. They reportedly had no chiefs, and perfect equality was established among them. Both were “equally ignorant of reading, writing, laws and government,” and had “no knowledge of a god,” according to local officials, suggesting that they conceptualized Chin tribes under their control as lacking in the characteristic markers of civilization in a Southeast Asian context: social hierarchy, hereditary rulership, literacy, continuity in government and Buddhist belief.

One of the higher-ranked among the elders was selected to be painted by Symes’ Bengali painter. While this was happening, Buchanan, through an interpreter, asked him where he would go after death. He answered that he would become a child and would be made so by the father

and mother of the world. Buchanan asked who these were. He replied that they grew in the earth, as trees grow in a field – one green, the other desiccated – and that they lived on a mountain. Buchanan later conversed with a group of elders who elaborated on these beliefs. They told him that long ago, the father and mother of the world were the king and queen of all Chin and that the souls of the dead went to them; they lived on a mountain. The Chin prayed to them, but only in the afterlife itself; in this world, they could not hear prayers. One of the Burmese village chiefs who ruled over the Chin later clarified this account, saying that the mountain referred to in these tales was in the abode of the independent Chin and that the Chin subject to the Burmese also carried the ashes of their dead up into the high mountains and buried them there, “where their gods reside.”

Buchanan’s encounter was likely with what the anthropologist Theodore Stern termed a ‘plains Chin’ community.⁷⁷ Such communities, on migrating into the Burmese-dominated lowlands, entered into a simultaneous relationship of economic, political and cultural subordination. This relationship introduced new pressures to acculturate - a pattern that can still be observed today with relatively one-sided linguistic adaptation.⁷⁸ This particular community’s move was likely in the recent past, because they still retained a variety of linguistic and cultural markers that separated them out from the wider Burmese population, as well as social and religious ties to highland communities; the plains Chin studied by Stern in the 1960s were much more thoroughly integrated into lowland life.

In the moment when they first enter into the colonial archive, the group or groups being referred to as Chin or Yo do not stand alone. They are deeply entangled with lowland political, economic, social and cultural networks in a way that makes it difficult to draw distinct boundaries between them and other ethnic groups;⁷⁹ exactly the pattern described in the 1960s by

Lehman, who argued that, rather than having developed in a vacuum, Chin society was ‘subnuclear,’ meaning that it was fundamentally oriented toward and adapted to living alongside plains dwellers.⁸⁰

Buchanan’s formal linguistic analysis is notable not for lending an artificial coherence to the relationship between language and identity in the region, but for drawing attention to its disconnect. Buchanan included in an article in *Asiatic Researches* a description of all the languages he had encountered in Burma – four dialects of Burmese, three Tai languages, the speech of Manipur, a Chin language, two Karen languages (Mon and Burmese Karens), the language of Pegu, those of Hindus and Muslims settled in Arakan, and that of Cachari slaves in the capital. On varieties of Burmese, he noted that the people of Arakan, Ava, the Yo states and Tenasserim spoke languages that appeared similar to him in most respects, yet all four groups differentiated themselves from each other (though Arakanese and Burmese acknowledged a common relation), and political fault lines ran between them: Arakan was a conquered state, the Yo were ruled under local princes in the same way the Shan were, and Tenasserim had traditionally been ruled by Siam. The same was true of the Tai, who, though displaying many similarities in language and culture, were fragmented both at the level of politics and identity.⁸¹

Among highland tribal groups, this disconnect was even more pronounced. Unlike in the lowlands, where there was a general agreement between different ethnic groups on terminologies and forms of identification, those of highlanders and lowlanders often bore little resemblance to each other. Buchanan used the Karens, another highland tribal group, as an example. The Burmese distinguished between Burmese and Mon Karens; some Karens themselves understood the distinction, but Buchanan surmised that it was likely because they had significantly acculturated and adopted Burmese ideas. He spoke to many Karen and recorded the encounters

in his diaries; such informants tended to prioritize lineage over ethnicity, also adopted Burmese cultural markers the further they came to the lowlands, and displayed extreme linguistic diversity, even in the case of settlements within relatively short distance of each other.

Buchanan came to the conclusion that although the peoples of the region bore shared physiological and linguistic markers, a localized conceptual ecumene, highland/lowland divisions and the vicissitudes of migration, cultural drift and political contestation had left the region configured along hopelessly entangled lines. "Language of all adventitious circumstances," he wrote, "is the surest guide in tracing the migrations and connections of nations; and how in a nation, which bears such strong marks of being one, radically the same, languages totally different should prevail, I cannot, at present, pretend to conjecture." He cautioned his contemporaries not to draw quick conclusions about ethnicity based on language, drawing parallels closer to home, pointing out that Bengal had been heavily influenced, culturally and linguistically, by both the Mughal Empire and the EIC, but that Bengalis were neither Persians nor Englishmen. Acculturation was far from evidence of a common origin, "a circumstance," he wrote, "to which, if antiquarians had been attentive, they would have been saved from the greater part of that etymological folly, which has so often exposed their pleasing science to the just ridicule of mankind."

As was the case in the other avenues of inquiry he pursued, Buchanan's ethnography of tribal people at the Burmese empire's ecological periphery consisted mostly of the collection of oral testimony, paired with rough geographical sketches from indigenous informants of a variety of backgrounds. These methods allowed him to capture evidence of the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity in the liminal spaces between highland and lowland in late eighteenth-century Burma. His observations reinforce the idea that ethnic categories were neither

primordial nor fixed but rather shaped by conquest, migration and cultural and economic exchanges. In recognizing this, Buchanan anticipated key insights later formalized in modern anthropology, demonstrating the extent to which colonial-era observers, when guided by inductive reasoning, could produce sophisticated depictions of other societies that did not artificially reduce their complexity to a European blueprint.

Conclusion

A text like Buchanan's Burma diaries cannot be sufficiently explained by focusing purely on his a priori beliefs about the world and their connection to the project of colonial domination. He was a Company servant working from within a specific 'episteme' – that of a pro-imperial Enlightenment rationalist, to paint him in the broadest possible strokes, an intellectual world that was the product of his career path and other aspects of his life trajectory.⁸² All writing is influenced by its social, political and intellectual context. Depending on the procedures used though, the results can be more or less empirically grounded. One's perspective influences what facts one pays attention to, and how they are interpreted, but it does not create the facts themselves,⁸³ which is why Buchanan was able to stumble upon realizations echoing those of modern scholars – claims about the lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty and ethnicity were just as supportable from the evidence then as they are now, even if people of Buchanan's time had little incentive to pay attention.

Most of the information Buchanan collected emerged from conversations with various people he met on his trip through Burma, as well as in post hoc interviews conducted in Calcutta with others who had traveled there, especially Indian mercenaries and merchants. As such, his writing is useful for understanding not only the intellectual and political history of European imperialism in Southeast Asia, but also the worldviews of his informants. The Burmese had their

own ideas about ethnicity and civilization and savagery which, although less standardized or connected to bureaucratic governance than those of colonial officials, were remarkably similar in their ideological effect; through cross-cultural encounters with different groups of precolonial ruling elites, these ideas bled into the colonial archive. These findings suggest that the relationship between knowledge and power, so well-studied in a colonial context, was present in some form and to some degree in non-European, premodern states as well, and that in the process of European colonization of South and Southeast Asia many of these ideas were taken up, reformatted, systematized and enshrined in the machinery of governance in a new way – but not invented.

The findings also speak to the multiplicity of voices to be found in early colonial records of cross-cultural encounter, including those of what might be characterized as subaltern groups – though in this case these were not the colonial state's subalterns, but those of another empire. The fragmentary evidence assembled here of the perspectives of such groups provides some degree of insight into the consciousness of conquered people in the Konbaung empire. Grievances were present, but expressed in a fragmentary and localized manner. Without the hallmarks of modern political consciousness – print culture, mass literacy and increased population circulation within the framework of a modern state – there was little possibility for connecting localized experiences into a single unified identity or cause.⁸⁴ Modern ideas of political equality and liberation have a specific history – they emerged in Europe largely in the eighteenth century and spread across the world in unison with European imperial expansion.⁸⁵ Before that point empire was the normative form of polity, even in very small states where expansion played out on a microcosmic scale.⁸⁶

The material collected here aligns neatly with a major trend in modern Southeast Asian studies historiography in that it contains plentiful evidence of the inadequacy of using a nation-state framework for the analysis of precolonial Burma. The Konbaung dynasty emerges here not as a proto-nation, but as an expansionist imperial power whose authority was exerted through a combination of direct rule in core regions and indirect control over tributary states and frontier populations. Rather than governing through uniform administrative structures, the Konbaung dynasty extended its influence into frontier regions through negotiated tributary alliances and the projection of military power, a loose and flexible but effective means of control over peripheral zones. One of its key strategies was a process of ‘cosmopolitan ingathering,’ in which subject populations from conquered territories – such as Manipuris, Arakanese, and Siamese – were forcibly relocated to the capital or other key population centers to serve as artisans, soldiers, or laborers, a practice that not only concentrated skilled manpower in the imperial core but also undermined the power bases of enemy states by siphoning away their subject populations.

This exercise of imperial power produced a marked lack of overlap between territory, sovereignty, and ethnicity. Outside of core areas, the Konbaung state ruled through a layered and flexible system of control, in which its sovereignty was partial, negotiated and shifting, rather than being bureaucratically imposed. Often, that control skipped over areas not conducive to settled agriculture, and extended only to tributary rulers; beneath that level, intermediaries mediated access to populations on the ground, and engaged in their own fractious political contestation. Ethnic identity was similarly in flux. The state’s social engineering of demography meant that entire populations could be uprooted, resettled, and reorganized in order to fulfill the resource demands of the state, leading to a situation in which many of the groups most directly under state control were non-Burmese, who developed hybrid cultural identities or assimilated

over time. Similar transformations also occurred on the highland/lowland verge, where ethnic differences between Burmese and Chin (highlander/lowlander) were mediated by a third category – Yo, frontier populations living next to highland areas but acculturated to Burmese lifeways and incorporated in varying degrees into the dynasty's political networks.

That such a detailed empirical picture so at odds with common assumptions about ethnicity and statehood in Buchanan's time can be recovered from his writing warrants a reconsideration of the scholarly consensus on colonial knowledge. There are many strident voices in this debate, echoing Edward Said's earlier formulation of European knowledge of the Orient as so politically tainted it was effectively fictional.⁸⁷ At its extremes, this was the case. At the other extreme, however, are figures like Buchanan, who secured real knowledge of other cultures, even if ultimately that too served the needs of the colonial state: see for example the handwritten notes taken by Buchanan after his return to Calcutta, in which he debriefed the Company's top officials, explaining to them exactly how to conquer Burma by taking advantage of divisions produced by the Konbaung dynasty's conquests.⁸⁸ An ugly use of his expertise, but in Machiavellian terms, a logical plan, and one that worked in the First Anglo-Burmese War, which coincidentally followed his little handwritten script surprisingly well, although it is likely that by that point it had long been forgotten.⁸⁹

Just because a perspective is sympathetic does not mean it is factually correct; vice versa, hostile perspectives can be built on sound empirical ground. If it were not so, modern intelligence gathering, for example, would not be possible. Knowledge production occupies two dimensions: stance and method. Foucault himself described this: that discourses or common beliefs were broadly diffused throughout society; but what lent certain discourses so much outsized power was the extent to which they were formalized, procedural – scientific.⁹⁰ Such

techniques produce more fine-grained and actionable knowledge than broad-based assumptions, even if they share a similar underlying ideological character and are crafted to achieve predetermined social or political goals. This was the case with colonial knowledge as well. Even if one accepts that all of it emerged from a shared set of assumptions and was oriented toward the singular purpose of domination – likely a reductive argument in and of itself – it does not necessarily follow that outdated values or unsavory intentions were always paired with ignorance. As David Hume, another clever eighteenth-century Scotsman, reminds us, facts and values are not the same.⁹¹

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Notes

- [1] Dirks, 'Colonial Histories and Native Informants', 279–313.
- [2] They are sometimes utilized as source material for making a wide variety of arguments unrelated to my own. See Leider, 'Natural Resources, Agricultural Produce and Commercialized Goods', 109–33; Lieberman, 'Secular Trends in Burmese Economic History', 1–31; Hall, *Europe and Burma*, 83; Bayly, *Empire and Information*, 118. None of these works cover indigenous knowledge or utilize the bulk of the text, which was focused on geography and ethnicity.
- [3] On colonial knowledge as a form of power linked to representation, classification, and imposed categories, see Said, *Orientalism*; Cohn, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge*; Dirks, *Castes of Mind*; Inden, *Imagining India*; Viswanathan, *Masks of Conquest*.
- [4] IOR/L/PS/19/56, letters from Michael Symes to Government, 25 April, 5 June, 2 July, 15 Aug. and 21 Oct. 1795; IOR/L/PS/19/56, minute from Sir John Shore, 4 Jan. 1796; Add. MSS 13872, Francis Buchanan, 'What to Do in Case of Rupture with Ava', July 1796.
- [5] Foucault, *Discipline and Punish*, 184–94; Foucault, *Madness and Civilization*; Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*, ch. 7; Harrell, 'Introduction: Civilizing Projects', 3–36; Hostetler, *Qing Colonial Enterprise*.
- [6] On the connections between European expansion, scientific and technical knowledge, navigation, military technology, and state power, see Cipolla, *Guns, Sails and Empires*; Parker, *The Military Revolution*; Headrick, *Power over Peoples*; Hoffman, *Why Did Europe Conquer the World?*; Gascoigne, *Science in the Service of Empire*.
- [7] Ludden, 'Orientalist Empiricism', 250–78.

- [8] Vicziany, 'Imperialism, Botany and Statistics', 625–60, 637–38; Prain, 'Sketch of the Life of Francis Hamilton', i–lxxv; Jhala, *An Endangered History*, ch. 1.
- [9] These are contained in the India Office archives, Mss Eur C12–14, D70–98, E68–73, G10–25; Kurukh D1; NHD 2–3. They were partly published later in printed form in Martin, *History, Antiquities, Topography, and Statistics of Eastern India*, vols. 1–3.
- [10] Bayly, *Empire and Information*.
- [11] Pemberton, *Report on the Eastern Frontier of British India*; Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes*.
- [12] Willem van Schendel, who said of Buchanan's surveys that they "provide us with the first detailed information in existence about many parts of rural Bengal," published the manuscript of his Chittagong journey because it had the potential to "push back the curtain of ignorance for that part of the country by some sixty years." Buchanan, Francis *Buchanan in Southeast Bengal*, x–xi.
- [13] Rennell, *Journals of Major James Rennell*; Edney, *Mapping an Empire*.
- [14] Guha, *A Rule of Property for Bengal*.
- [15] Cohn, *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge*; Dirks, *Castes of Mind*; Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*.
- [16] Scott, *Seeing Like a State*.
- [17] Dalrymple, *The Anarchy*.
- [18] Daston, 'The Empire of Observation', 81–113.
- [19] Leider, 'Alaungmintaya', 13–41.
- [20] Mss Eur C12, Francis Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava'; Symes, *Embassy to Ava*, vols. 1–2; Buchanan, 'Map of the Route

between Tartary and Amarapura', 32–42; Buchanan, 'Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava', 262–71; Buchanan, 'Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan', 230–39; Buchanan, 'Map Constructed by a Native of Taunu', 75–84; Buchanan, 'Map of the Tarout Shan Territory', 71–75; Buchanan, 'Map of the Country North from Ava', 76–87; Buchanan, 'Two Maps of Zaenmae or Yangoma', 59–67; Buchanan, 'Map Drawn by a Native of Dawae or Tavay', 228–36.

[21] Cohn, 'Notes on the History of the Study of Indian Society and Culture', 3–29.

[22] For example, Buchanan wrote that the map had been drawn up for him by "a man in great poverty, who said, that, at the time, he was a slave of Eimshe mayn, the heir-apparent of the kingdom, and who probably had been reduced to the servile state by debt, as his intelligence and manners denoted a person who had held considerable rank, and received a good education." Buchanan, 'Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava', 262–71.

[23] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 118–20.

[24] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 49–50.

[25] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 74–5.

[26] Symes, Embassy to Ava, vol. 2, 90–91.

[27] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 74–76; Buchanan, 'Map of the Route between Tartary and Amarapura', 32–42; Buchanan, 'Map of the Countries Subject to the King of Ava', 262–71; Buchanan, 'Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan, or Pagan', 230–39; Buchanan, 'Map Constructed by a Native of Taunu', 75–84; Buchanan, 'Map of the Tarout Shan Territory', 71–75; Buchanan, 'Map of the

- Country North from Ava', 76–87; Buchanan, 'Two Maps of Zaenmae or Yangoma', 59–67; Buchanan, 'Map Drawn by a Native of Dawae or Tavay', 228–36.
- [28] Buchanan, 'Map of the Route between Tartary and Amarapura', 32.
- [29] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 88.
- [30] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 55–56; Rennell, *Journals of Major James Rennell*.
- [31] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 128.
- [32] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 95–6.
- [33] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 62.
- [34] Scott, *The Art of Not Being Governed*; Harrell, 'Introduction: Civilizing Projects', 3–36.
- [35] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 49–50.
- [36] Myint-U, *The Making of Modern Burma*, chs. 3–4.
- [37] Envoys and royals from these states were observed at court by the next Company ambassador. Cox, *Journal of a Residence in the Burmhan Empire*, *passim*.
- [38] For metaphors on the resemblances between Southeast Asian interstate relations and the model of the solar system, see Lieberman, *Strange Parallels*, 1:22–25; Tambiah, 'The Galactic Polity in Southeast Asia', 503–34.
- [39] The Kachin, for example, were first known to the British through ethnic monikers borrowed from surrounding lowlanders such as the Burmese or Assamese; it was only in the 1830s when they realized that these groups, though organized along lineage lines, shared enough in common culturally that they could be considered a single whole. Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma*; Sadan, *Being and Becoming Kachin*, 29–34.
- [40] Government of India, *Census of India, 1891*, vol. 9, *Burma Report*, vol. 1, ch. 10.

- [41] Myint-U, *Making of Modern Burma*, chs. 3–4 contain good information on these wars. Symes, *Embassy to Ava*, vol. 1 has a historical overview given to him by veterans of them; documents related to them can also be found in Than Tun, *Royal Orders of Burma*, vols. 3–5, in particular the 19 Jan. 1759 order discussing Alaungpaya's initial attack and subjugation of the kingdom.
- [42] Lieberman, 'Political Consolidation in Burma', 152–68, at 167.
- [43] For a comprehensive overview of the relationship between slavery and warfare and premodern Southeast Asia, see Charney, *Southeast Asian Warfare*, ch. 9.
- [44] Symes, *Embassy to Ava*, vol. 2, 6.
- [45] Symes, *Embassy to Ava*, vol. 1, 89–90.
- [46] Ward, 'Slavery in Southeast Asia', 163–85.
- [47] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 71.
- [48] Symes, *Embassy to Ava*, vol. 2, 57–58.
- [49] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 72.
- [50] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 73–4.
- [51] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 74–5.
- [52] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 74–6.
- [53] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 95.
- [54] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 100.
- [55] Mackenzie, *History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes*, 145–49, 217–45, 269–87.

- [56] Pemberton, Report on the Eastern Frontier of British India, 32–50; Mackenzie, History of the Relations of the Government with the Hill Tribes, 145–49, 217–45, 269–87; Sinha, Tribal Politics and State Systems.
- [57] Mangrai, The Shan States and the British Annexation, ch. 5.
- [58] Giersch, Asian Borderlands, 97–127.
- [59] Lieberman, Burmese Administrative Cycles, 113–30.
- [60] Lieberman, 'Political Consolidation in Burma', 152–68.
- [61] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 85–91.
- [62] Mangrai, Shan States and the British Annexation, 15–81.
- [63] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 85–88.
- [64] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 79.
- [65] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 83; the term 'little king' is closely associated with the work of Bernard Cohn and Nicholas Dirks. Cohn, 'Political Systems in Eighteenth Century India', 312–20; Dirks, The Hollow Crown.
- [66] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 135.
- [67] Buchanan was carrying with him during his travels copies of the maps produced by the French Enlightenment geographer Jean-Baptiste d'Anville, compiled from information relayed by French Jesuits employed in mapping activities in Yunnan and elsewhere by the Qing court. His maps endowing China with European-style borders are included in Du Halde, Description Geographique, vols. 1–4.
- [68] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 85–88, 92.
- [69] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 97–9.

- [70] On ethnic fluidity and the social and political construction of ethnicity in highland Burma, see Leach, *Political Systems of Highland Burma*; Leach, 'The Frontiers of "Burma"', 49–68; Lehman, *The Structure of Chin Society*, 3–5, 28–39. See also Lehman, 'Ethnic Categories in Burma', 93–124.
- [71] Okell, 'The Yaw Dialect of Burmese', 199–202.
- [72] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 109–14.
- [73] Buchanan, 'Map of the Vicinity of Pauk-gan, or Pagan', 230–39.
- [74] Hamilton [Buchanan], 'Frontier between Part of Bengal and the Kingdom of Ava', 54.
- [75] Sangermano, *A Description of the Burmese Empire*, 33–34.
- [76] Buchanan, 'Observations during Travels through Burma on Mission to Ava', 118–20.
- [77] Stern, 'Language Contact between Related Languages', 1–28.
- [78] McCormick, 'Hierarchy and Contact', 42–43.
- [79] Robinne and Sadan, 'Postscript', 299–308; Barth, *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries*.
- [80] Lehman, *Structure of Chin Society*, 221–29.
- [81] Buchanan, 'Comparative Vocabulary', 219–40.
- [82] For more on this, see Vicziany, 'Imperialism, Botany and Statistics'; Prain, 'Sketch of the Life of Francis Hamilton'; and Jhala, *An Endangered History*, ch. 1.
- [83] For realist accounts that distinguish a mind-independent world from socially mediated perception, description, or interpretation, see Bhaskar, *A Realist Theory of Science*; Hacking, *Representing and Intervening*; Searle, *The Construction of Social Reality*, ch. 1.
- [84] Anderson, *Imagined Communities*, chs. 2–4; Duara, *Rescuing History from the Nation*; Winichakul, *Siam Mapped*; Osterhammel, *The Transformation of the World*.

- [85] Hunt, *Inventing Human Rights*, 15–34; Hobsbawm, *Nations and Nationalism since 1780*; Bayly, *The Birth of the Modern World*.
- [86] Burbank and Cooper, *Empires in World History*; Darwin, *After Tamerlane*.
- [87] Said, *Orientalism*, 6.
- [88] Buchanan, 'What to Do in Case of Rupture with Ava'.
- [89] Pemberton, *Report on the Eastern Frontier of British India*; Snodgrass, *Narrative of the Burmese War*; Wilson, *Documents Illustrative of the Burmese War*.
- [90] Foucault, *The Archaeology of Knowledge*, 205; Foucault, *Discipline and Punish*, 184–94; Foucault, 'Truth and Juridical Forms', 1–90.
- [91] Hume, *A Treatise of Human Nature*, 469–70.

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